

One time in AP Government class, I got a call from a source and literally looked at my teacher and said, “I have to step out and take this. It’s for work.” He took my phone away.

I occasionally babysat too. This was good for extra cash and I enjoyed hanging out with the kids. I met these families through my synagogue, and I’m still friends with some of my former charges on Facebook. (Yes, I am that old.)

Working with the youths is an easy-to-acquire but hard-to-do job for someone in high school. At one point, I was hired as a summer camp counselor, which required me to spend the summer in the woods in Georgia helping 13-year-old girls learn about tampons. That took care of food and lodging, but it was also a nonstop twenty-four-hour exhausting high-stakes gig.

One weird summer, I also worked as a secretary for my mom’s divorce and child custody law firm, answering phones and filing paperwork. This led to many diary entries about how depressing the job was and how sad it was to see kids being used as props by their parents. I railed a lot about the injustices I was witnessing, which in the end opened my eyes to problems within our legal system—but also, at 15, it was a bit much for my brain to handle every day. (My mom is a strong woman.)

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Jobs-wise, you kind of have to take what you can get in high school. I acquired a lot of these jobs through people I knew who took a chance on me. And if you’re in high school, you’re often trying to get your first job, so you don’t have a full résumé to prove you’re a good employee (which, obviously, does not include eating the food you’re supposed to be serving on the job. Shame on you, rascalion Gaby).

Aside from being an early way to start saving for the future, contribute to your family, or have your own spending money, getting a job in high school looks pretty good on a college application—as long as it doesn’t have a negative impact on your GPA. College admissions counselors I spoke to said admissions offices take into account job experience as much as “extracurriculars” because